Swindle

By Gordon Korman

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 1-3)** Sneaking out at night – Helpful Hints: 1. When lying to your parents, maintain eye contact. 2) Ask permission to attend the FAKE SLEEPOVER. 3) Meet at the Old Rockford House at 8:30 pm Friday. 4) Enter through missing plans in boarded-up window, first floor, east side. Bring your sleeping bag. The old Rockford house is a condemned building that will be demolished tomorrow morning. There will be no beds, no running water, no furniture, no lights, no TV!

BEN: We probably shouldn't have put in the part about no TV . . . . maybe they're just late.

GRIFFIN: Nine o'clock is late. Ten-thirty is a no-show.

BEN: Come on, Griffin, what difference does it make if two people or two hundred people spend the last night in a condemned building. They're never even going to know about it. Maybe the other kids were scared.

GRIFFIN: Of what? Dust? The rain? A whole night with no TV?

BEN: This house is supposed to be haunted. You know the rumors.

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 6)** Oh, come on! There's no such thing as a haunted house. *(a gust of wind blew through the eves and an unearthly moaning sound echoed around them – Griffin reacts with fear)* No offense, Ben, but shut up. You're starting to creep me out. *(Griffin clicks on his flashlights and begins to look around)* [I'll explore by myself!] **(Pg 12-13)** *(He begins to wander the empty husk of the Rockford house. A creature lands in his hair (a bat). Full-on terror rocks him. He slaps desperately at his head, and goes down to the floor – the creature disentangles itself and flies off)* You're okay. Maximum gross, minimum danger. *(He grabs his flashlight and shines it around, then screams)* Some kind of old-fashioned desk!

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(By the glow of his flashlight Griffin plays with the many drawers and compartments, but one drawer won't open – He accidently touches a release switch) **(Pg 14-15)** A release switch! This must be some kind of hiding place. *(He looks inside the drawer)* A baseball card! GEORGE HERMAN RUTH . . . (BABE) RUTH. No way! Old baseball cards [are] worth a lot of money! *(He races back to where he left Ben and waves the card under his nose)* **(Pg 20-21)** Read it and weep!

BEN: Babe Ruth – wow! Do you think it's real?

GRIFFIN: *(Looking more closely at the card)* It's probably not valuable. I never get that lucky . . . *(thinking)* There are experts in this kind of thing.

BEN: Palomino's Emporium?

GRIFFIN: We'll get an appraisal!

INTRODUCTION

After a mean collector named Swindle cons him out of a most valuable baseball card, Griffin Bing must put together a band of misfits to break into Swindle's compound and recapture the card. There are many things standing in their way -- but Griffin and his team are going to get back what's rightfully his . . . Even if hijinks ensue.

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(Ben and Griffin enter Palomino's Emporium and spy a short stocky man behind the front counter Thick glasses make his eyes appear twice their size.)

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 23)** Are you Mr. S. Wendell Palomino?

PALOMINO: What can I do for you, young gentlemen?

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 24-26)** *(Pulling out his Babe Ruth card)* I'm thinking of selling this. I hear you guarantee the best prices. *(Palomino extends a pudgy hand to take the card. As he looks at it his eyes get wider and his busy eyebrows shoot up high. He is obviously excited about the card and Griffin and Ben get excited too)* It's valuable?

PALOMINO: *(instantly reigning in his enthusiasm. He snorts in disdain)* Well, it would be – if it was real. *(He takes out a large magnifying glass and expounds)* You see this

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solid blue border? That was striped in the original. That's how we know it's a copy. I'll give you a hundred bucks for it.

GRIFFIN: *(Sighing heavily)* A hundred and fifty!

PALOMINO: *(chuckling)* You drive a hard bargain, sonny boy. Tell you what – one twenty.

GRIFFIN: Sold! *(Hands over the card)*

PALOMINO: *(Palomino counts out his payment. Palomino then turns and makes an elaborate show of opening his safe, putting the card inside and closing the safe again. He turns and is surprised to see the boys still standing at the counter)* **(Pg 27)** Pleasure doing business with you!

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 26)** If the card isn't valuable, how come you need to keep it in a safe?

PALOMINO: This isn't Toys 'R' Us, sonny boy. We take security seriously at Palomino's Emporium. *(***(Pg 61)** *Luthor, Palomino's guard dog Doberman comes out of nowhere, snarling and growling.)* **(Pg 36)** That's okay, Luthor. *(***(Pg 27)** *As Palomino calms the dog, Griffin and Ben slink out of the shop.)*

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(Griffin settles in a home to watch some television. As he clicks through the channels, one station catches his attention – He turns up the sound and watches in shock)

PALOMINO: **(pg 32-34)** *(Holding up the Babe Ruth card for a group of reporters and cameramen)* . . . when I bought the collection, I had no idea . . . but the instant I laid eyes on it . . . I mean . . wow!!

REPORTER: There are a lot of similar cards out there. What makes this one so special?

PALOMINO: It was printed in 1920, Ruth's first season as a Yankee. But look at the picture.

CAMERA MAN: *(Zooming in)* That's a Red Sox uniform!

PALOMINO: That's what makes this card especially valuable.

REPORTER: How much is it worth, Wendell? What are you selling it for?

PALOMINO: [Well] The people at Worthington's think it could be the second card in

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history to break the million-dollar barrier.

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 39)** I've been **cheated**!!

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(At school the next day, Griffin hatches his plan at recess)

BEN: **(Pg 41-42)** You want to pull a what?

GRIFFIN: Shhhh! A heist.

BEN: A robbery. That's stealing!

GRIFFIN: Not stealing. Stealing **BACK**. There's a big difference.

BEN: S. Wendell. Never trust anybody whose name sounds like swindle.

GRIFFIN: He's the ultimate Swindle. And the only way to get that card back is to take it. What do you say? **(Pg 44)** *(He notices a group of kids who were supposed to be at the Rockford House, but didn't show up)* Hey! What about the old Rockford house, huh? Where were you on Friday night? **(Pg 45)** Pitch?

PITCH: My family was at the indoor rock wall. I completely spaced.

GRIFFIN: Savannah??

SAVANNAH: I couldn't be there on Friday. Madame Curie was about to litter. *(takes a hamster from her bag)* My hamster. *(rapidly produces more and more hamsters from the bag)* It was a boy . . . and another boy . . . and three girls.

GRIFFIN: Logan??

LOGAN: *(Haughtily)* Well, I didn't miss it for any dumb reason like that. I have an audition for an acne cream commercial. I had to stay home and rehearse.

PITCH: We're all sorry, Griffin. We shouldn't have flaked out on you that way. Our loss.

SAVANNAH: **(Pg 121)** This is about your stupid baseball card, isn't it!

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 122-124)** *(in a stage whisper)* Before we go any further. I need your word that you can't tell anybody about this. Ever . . . [It's] A Babe Ruth card from 1920 – the kind collectors pay big bucks for. Swindle saw a couple of kids, and

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he took advantage of us because he didn't think we could do anything about it. We're going to show him he was wrong! [He] told the news it could go for over a million. Equal shares!

LOGAN: *(dreamily)* I could afford . . . . acting lessons!

PITCH: I could take my family climbing at Yosemite!

SAVANNAH: Yeah, it's a lot of money. But that kind of cash doesn't come easy. You're talking about a robbery.

GRIFFIN: You're right. If we all work together, we can pull it off. *(Griffin reveals his PLAN)* **(Pg 136)** **The Great Baseball Card Heist** **(Pg 124)** We break into Swindle's house through a skylight on the roof. Pitch, that's where you come in! Swindle has a guard dog that sleeps in the house. The dog's no joke, but Savannah can handle him.

LOGAN: **(Pg 125-126)** Where do I fit into all this? I'm an actor, not a burglar.

GRIFFIN: Swindle lives across the street from the great-grandaddy of all nosy neighbors. We need you to distract him during the operation. We can do this! Now, who's on board?

PITCH: **(Pg 127)** Count me it. Somebody's got to teach this creep a lesson!

LOGAN: Me, too. It's the ultimate challenge for an actor.

SAVANNAH: **(Pg 129)** Yeah, right – like I've got a choice. I have to go along to protect poor Luthor!

GRIFFIN: **(Pg 160)** Ben's going to take the lookout spot in the front bushes. *(Ben reacts with his characteristic enthusiasm)* **(pg 129)** It's a go then!

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NARRATOR: **(Pg 133)** The next day, Logan Kellerman started up the walk at 530 Park Avenue, a package under his arm . . .

LOGAN: *(doing some theatrical warm-ups as he gets into character. When he's ready, he approaches the door and rings the bell)*

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MULRONEY: What can I do for you son?

LOGAN: I live at 530 University, and this parcel was delivered to our house by mistake. Are you *(consulting the label on the package)* E. Mulroney?

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GRIFFIN: **(Pg 157)** *(giving the final pep talk to the rest of the heist crew)* What we're dong tonight isn't about a baseball card. It isn't even about money. Tonight we show that fairness isn't something that's just for adults, and that you can't get away with dumping on people just because they're younger than you. Tonight we make our statement! Okay . . . Let's go! *(Pantomime putting on a climbing harness and extending a ladder on the side of the house. They make it to the roof, open the sky light and drop down inside the house)* **(Pg 168-169)** Everybody – remember to keep you gloves on. No fingerprints! *(Luthor lets out a long low growl and heads toward the group viciously)* Savannah!!

SAVANNAH: Luthor! ***Sweetie***! Good boy – beautiful boy! Oh, I missed you so much! *(Luthor interrupts himself in mid-ounce, landing on his back and wriggling like a puppy, presenting it's belly to be scratched.)*

GRIFFIN: *(releasing a huge breath he had been holding)* Okay, guys. Split up. We have to find that [card]. **(Pg 183)** It's in this house somewhere! *(Pantomime a search for the card – until he ultimately finds it and holds it aloft)* **(Pg 191)** This is the greatest moment of my life! *(They beat a hasty retreat through the back door of the house, Griffin grabs Ben on the way out)*

BEN: **(Pg 207)** I've always had a lot of respect for you, man. But I never dreamed we had a prayer of pulling off what we did tonight!

GRIFFIN: If you've got the right plan, that's all you need!

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NEWS REPORTER: **(Pg 216)** In what is being called the most spectacular robbery in history, a 1920 baseball card valued as high as one million dollars was stolen

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from its owner's home last night. Police are investigating leads, including the harnesses and an extension ladder found at the scene.

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GRIFFIN: **(Pg 235)** *(to his posse)* Don't worry. I'll take all the blame. My plan, my problem. To be honest, I can't believe the cops haven't come for me yet. *(Knock at the door, Griffin is handcuffed and taken to the police station.)*

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POLICE CHIEF: **(Pg 244-245)** *(pulling a sheet of paper from the typewriter and placing it on the table in front of Griffin)* Sign here at the bottom.

GRIFFIN: *(Scared beyond belief)* A confession? Worse? What does it say?

POLICE CHIEF: Take it easy. It's just a statement that you found the baseball card inside the old Rockford house. There's a 97-year-old lady in Baltimore – the last surviving member of the original Rockford family. The card is really hers. Palomino is out of luck. *(Griffin reacts)* I hope you know how lucky you are. Mr. Palomino isn't going to press charges. He wants to avoid an investigation into whether he broke the law when he cheated you. It's a pretty happy ending all around – probably happier than you deserve.

GRIFFIN: Thanks, Officer. Thanks, a lot!

NARRATOR: **(Pg 251)** Palomino's Emporium closed its doors for good The store never recovered from the scandal. S. Wendell moved to California, leaving only his dog Luthor behind. The Doberman spent less than an hour at the pound before being adopted by Savannah Drysdale. It was a match made in heaven. *(Pantomime their reunion)*

SAVANNAH: **(Pg 169)** Luthor! ***Sweetie***! Good boy – good boy! Oh, I missed you so much!

NARRATOR: What everybody knew, but no one was willing to admit, was that the most interesting thing that had ever happened in this sleepy little community was the Great Baseball Card Heist!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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